Understanding disability

Everyday understanding and inclusion

Disability is different for everyone

Disability can involve movement, sight, hearing, learning, mental health or other aspects of everyday life. Some disabilities are present from birth; others develop later. Many are not immediately visible.

Barriers can make life harder

Steps, small print, inaccessible websites or unhelpful attitudes can prevent people taking part. Removing barriers can give people more choice and independence. Disability does not tell you what someone can achieve.

Support should fit the person

Someone might use a wheelchair, hearing aid, clear written information or extra time. Needs may change. Ask before helping, speak directly to the person and respect the words they use to describe themselves.

What about disability rights?

In England, Scotland and Wales, the Equality Act 2010 generally protects people whose physical or mental impairment has a substantial, long-term negative effect on normal daily activities. There are special rules and exceptions. Northern Ireland has different law.

Understanding helps

Reasonable adjustments reduce disability-related disadvantage, such as accessible equipment or flexible working arrangements. Scope, Acas or an advice service can help you explore support.

General information only, not medical or legal advice. Rights and support depend on the circumstances. Seek appropriate professional advice about your own situation.

Sources and further reading (clickable in the PDF):

Scope: disability and barriers
GOV.UK: definition of disability
Acas: reasonable adjustments

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